



XXVI

International Conference of the Society for Human Ecology

ECOLOGY, POLITICS, AND JUSTICE: WORKING TOWARDS THE PLURIVERSE

University of Mons | June 18–21, 2025 | Mons, Belgium

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Session Title:

Edible Forest Foods of the Dzao community in Ba Vi National Park -Traditional Knowledge and Agroecological Potential.

Abstract:

Together with local stakeholders we conducted exploratory research to document the edible forest foods of the Dzao ethnic community living in the buffer zone of Ba Vi National Park. The Dzao people, who historically resided in the upper parts of Ba Vi Mountain, have sustained a sophisticated system of traditional ecological knowledge (TEK) regarding the use of forest plants for food, medicine, and well-being. This knowledge is passed down across generations through forest walks, spiritual practices, and lived experience, demonstrating a rigorous empirical approach akin to scientific inquiry.

Through a transdisciplinary process, we engaged Dzao elders, women, and youth, alongside Ba Vi National Park rangers, scientists, and development practitioners. Fieldwork in the park and surrounding villages identified over 40 edible species, contributing to a deeper understanding of the role of traditional food environments in biodiversity conservation and nutrition. The co-production of knowledge with Indigenous experts highlights how TEK is a dynamic and adaptive system, refined over generations through direct interaction with the landscape.

As urban food systems in Hanoi and surrounding areas evolve, agroecological approaches, including renewed interest in forest-derived foods, are gaining traction. Integrating Dzao TEK into conservation and food system planning presents an opportunity to bridge Indigenous and scientific knowledge, fostering sustainable food environments that honor cultural identity, biodiversity, and ecological resilience. This case study contributes to human ecology by exploring the intersections of traditional food systems, conservation, and food sovereignty.

Keywords:

Edible forests, traditional ecological knowledge, nutrition, conservation, agroecology